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TODAY'S TALKER - Lawmaker hopping to ban chemical that makes Peeps colorful

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This Easter, Americans will devour more than 1 billion Peeps — those radiant marshmallow chicks whose appearance on store shelves is as much a herald of spring as azaleas at the Masters.

What makes the treats so vibrant is erythrosine, a chemical that shows up on ingredient labels as Red No. 3. It's one of several chemicals used to color some of the most popular candy in the country. Both chemicals have been linked to cancer. More than 30 years ago, U.S. regulators banned Red No. 3 from makeup.

The U.S. still has not banned the chemical from food, to the dismay of some consumer safety groups.

Now, a state lawmaker wants to ban erythrosine and titanium dioxide in California, plus three other chemicals used in everyday favorites like tortillas and some store brand sodas.

The bill has prompted headlines around the world declaring California wants to ban Skittles and other candy.

Assembly member Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat who authored the bill, said he wants to ban the chemicals, not the candy. He said plenty of alternative ingredients are available, noting the chemicals are already banned in Europe and that companies still find a way to sell candy there.

The National Confectioners Association, the trade group that represents candy companies, says it's not that easy. Tastes vary across cultures, it said, meaning just because a candy is accepted by Europeans doesn't mean it will be received well in the United States. Plus, changing ingredients would be a hardship for regional candy makers who don't sell their products overseas, according to the trade group.

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